Finishing the Task – Transform World
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Introduction: Pastors, friends, greetings to you in the matchless name of our Lord Jesus Christ. This is the day the Lord has made. We shall rejoice and be glad in it because, as Habakkuk the prophet assures us, the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea (2:14). Fellow servant, today, know that you are on the winning side and invited to join a growing team of pastors and Christian leaders worldwide to embrace God's biblical mandate to make disciples of all the people groups.

As the revelation of God came to Habakkuk, from being "a prophet in crisis" he became "a prophet in praise," may that be so for you, servant of the Most-High God, as you consider the challenge of Finishing the Task – Transform World. We are grateful for FTT which is one of the initiatives focused on finishing the overall Great Commission that, according to the related website, has become "a movement of 1,600 churches and organizations coming together to reach the Unengaged, Unreached People Groups (UUPGs) – those with no access to a Bible, believers, or a body of Christ" (See Finishing the Task.com).

You may be tempted to complain, like Habakkuk, who questioned almighty God in chapter one, verse two through four when he prayed: "How long, Lord, must I call for help, but you do not listen? Or cry out to you, "Violence!" but you do not save? Why do you make me look at injustice? Why do you tolerate wrongdoing? Destruction and violence are before me; there is strife, and conflict abounds. Therefore, the law is paralyzed, and justice never prevails. The wicked hem in the righteous, so that justice is perverted."

Habakkuk, whose name means "he that embraces," was called by God to embrace the problem of "justice in the world," and the mystery of God's ways and purpose concerning evil, in his day, even as God spoke to his prophet as recorded in chapter one and verse five, "Look at the nations and watch, and be utterly amazed. I am going to do something in your days that you would not believe, even if you were told. I am raising the Babylonians, that ruthless and impetuous people, who sweep across the whole earth to seize dwellings not their own."



Siege of Jerusalem, 587 BC

And it was so, just as God said. According to Jewish reckoning, from the taking of the first captives to the return from Babylon to the Land of Israel, due to Cyrus's decree, it was indeed 70-year captivity.



In his second complaint regarding God's subsequent corrective action in using the Chaldeans – the most ruthless of nations as his instruments to occupy their homes and punish His people – Habakkuk wondered: Why would God's chosen people to be allowed to suffer in this way?



Babylonian Captivity

Habakkuk could understand neither the gross sin of his people in Judah who had fallen into severe moral and social decay, with violence, oppression of the poor, and corruption nor God's seeming indifference to the severe chastisement by the ruthless cruelty of the pagan Babylonians.

Similarly, you may be struggling with injustices, along with every one of God's servants, as we are being called to serve in a post-COVID-19 of disruption in all aspects of society. It is a new world in which uncertainty unloads collective confusion which confounds. Our resilience is being tested. How do we live a life pleasing to God in a doomed and dying world? In every country, action-domains driving the economy, health, and governance are being formulated. God's people are asking the question, "when the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do?" (Psalm 11:3).

We can learn from the actions of Habakkuk how to respond in the devastation of the institutions in his day. From wondering and worrying in chapter 1, to watching and waiting in chapter 2 to worshiping and witnessing in chapter 3. Fellow minister of the gospel, that is where we need to be today, joyfully serving our master and sharing the Good News, "Jesus saves." Why? because God is building His church during a dying world and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. Our mission has not changed.

God loves a cheerful giver and wants to use your life and my life as His servants in our day giving of ourselves to discipling the nations as mandated by Jesus to his disciples. In koine Greek, it reads, "Panta Ta Ethnē[1]" which can be translated "all people groups," or "all peoples," or "all nations." The Content Innovation Team (CIT) at Logos Bible Software which now has compiled more than 20,000 resources defines the meaning of a Greek or Hebrew word within a specific verse of the Bible which they call the Sense definition. They conclude that in Matthew 28:19 it means "a large group of people (people group) based on various cultural, physical, or geographical ties!"[1]

The mandate of our master to his disciples in Matthew 28:19 "to make disciples of all people groups" has been fulfilled such that there are no more Unreached People Groups within which "there is no indigenous community of believing Christians able to evangelize this people group."

In the climactic center of this revelation from God to his servant Habakkuk, between his beginning question "how long must I cry?" and his final words "I will rejoice in the God of my salvation," we discover the reason for the rejoicing as stated in Habakkuk 2:14 which is this fact. It is because of an emerging transformed world as "The Task" is finished: This world, with all of its peoples, will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea.

Fellow servants, Habakkuk offers us a comprehensive mission vision for all followers of God birthed in a context of crisis so relevant to us today in our world and rooted in the notion that the righteous shall live by faith.

The Central Proposition in this message from Habakkuk is this: God is advancing His Kingdom purposes in our day – leading to a world filled with the knowledge of His glory – and inviting his servants to join Him on His mission of transformation by doing the following three things: I. Reflect on the vision II. Write down the vision, and III. Run with the Vision.

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[1]Luis Bush, *The Meaning of Ethne in Matthew 28:19*, (Mission Frontiers), September 1, 2013

I. Reflect on the vision of a world filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea to Finishing-the Task – Transform World examining the Biblical Roots
II. Write down the vision of a world filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea
III. Run with the Vision of a world filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea

I. **Finishing the Task -- Transform World begins with Reflection on the Word of God.** What is God is saying to us in His Word?

As dedicated pastors and servants of God, we look for a biblical basis for our ministry at home and at large which calls for serious reflection in His Word. Finishing the Task, mandated by Jesus to His disciples is recorded in Mathew 28:19 as *making disciples of all the ethnē* which can be interpreted as establishing a church planting movement among every distinct ethnolinguistic people.

Our conviction grows as we discover the fact that the spiritual and biblical roots of FINISHING THE TASK run deep, into the Old Testament revelation of God directly to Habakkuk the prophet when He said: "Look at the nations and watch—and be utterly amazed. I am going to do something in your days that you would not believe, even if you were told."

Since Habakkuk is generally believed to have written his book in the mid-to-late 7th century BC—not long before the Babylonians' siege and capture of Jerusalem in 586 BC--that would mean that the biblical basis for finishing the task goes back more than twenty-seven centuries.

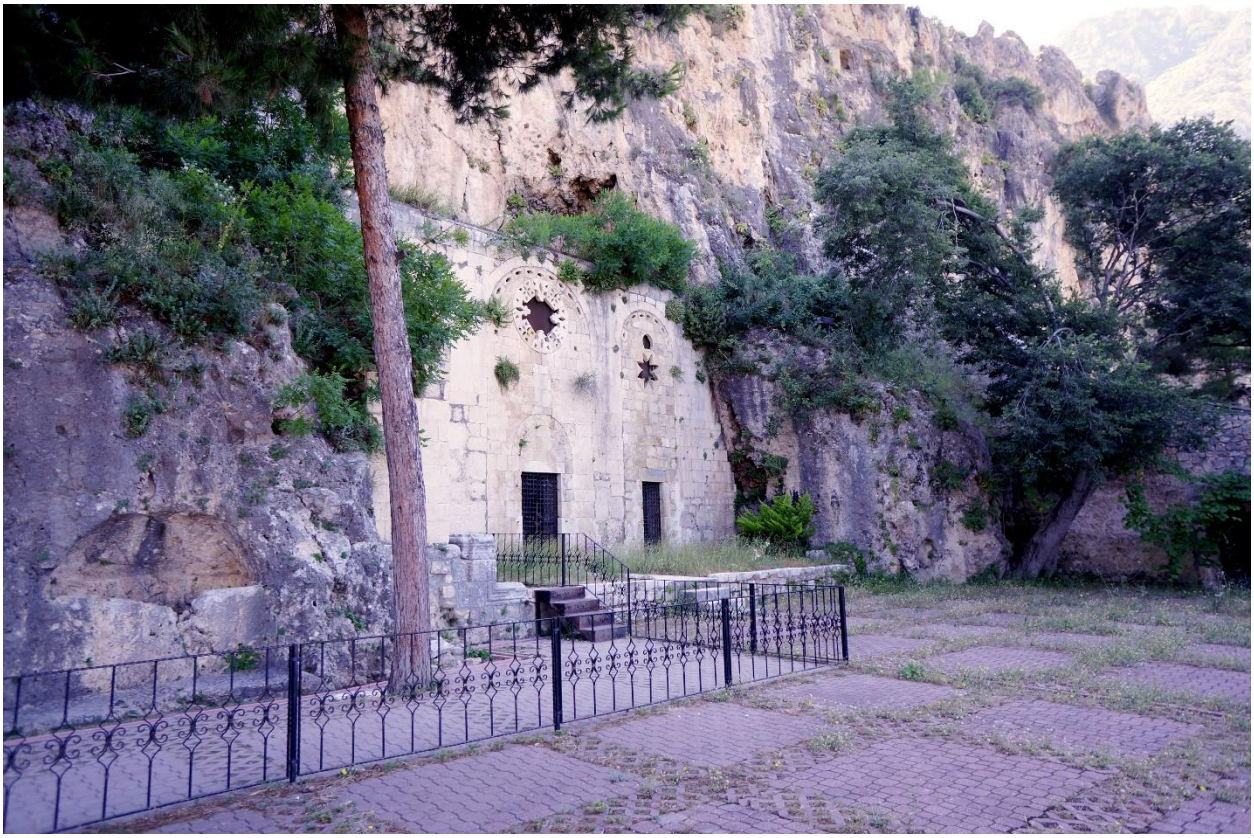
But the vision of finishing the task goes back even earlier – at least another 170 years. It was in 760 BC, around 174 years earlier, according to Isaiah the prophet, God calls his servant, Israel, **to a new task**: to be a light to the nations—the ethnē—saying: "It is too light a thing that you should be my servant to raise the tribes of Jacob and to bring back the preserved of Israel;
I will make you as a light for the nations, that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth" (see Isaiah 49:6).

Finishing the task has been on the heart of God for an exceptionally long time. It is not just a New Testament revelation. So, when Luke writes the Book of Acts, he references the final words of Paul's first sermon warning his hearers not to reject God's work in Christ for the ethnē. When the gospel is declared, one must make a decision. Refuse to believe and perish, or will you believe and be justified?

The point of the sermon was to prove that Jesus had fulfilled the Davidic promises that offered forgiveness and justification to those who believed regardless of their ethnicity. In so doing Paul interprets Habakkuk 1:5 as an astonishment of God's work not only to use the cruel Chaldeans to discipline His people but aimed ultimately at the conversion of all the ethnē regardless of their ethnicity (See Acts 13:41). It was no surprise, the next week when they came together that there arose a division between the Jews and Gentiles as some Jews reacted violently against Paul and his message. Paul and Barnabas would now team up to share the gospel of Christ among the ethnē.

Consider, as historical background, that Peter's mission to the Gentiles ends in Acts 12 and Paul's mission to the Gentiles which begins in Acts 13. Barnabus found Paul, then called Saul, brought him to Antioch, where the disciples of Jesus were first called "Christians" (Acts 11:25-26). They remained for a

whole year ministering together at the Antioch church from which they would be sent out together as a missionary team.



When Paul and Barnabas came through on the first missionary journey we read in Acts 13:2-3+) that "They were ministering to the Lord and fasting." They were sharpening their spiritual senses as they pursued an experiential relationship with the Lord Jesus Christ. They realized it was not just a matter of knowing about Him but knowing Him through shared experiences. This allowed them to focus on the fullness of God's Word and God's will.

It was while they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, that the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them." That was a New Testament spiritual and biblical root of finishing the task.

This sets a good example for all of us, servants of God, who are serious about finishing the task. It is something we must do and invite all of the servants of God in our cities to do, as we envision finishing the task by 2030. It is about ministering to the Lord to worship him alone in all that you do. As you minister to the Lord God will show you what you must do. Now is the time. Now is the opportunity.

But you may ask yourself, how does Habakkuk 1:5 fit in this picture? Paul quoted this verse from the Prophet Habakkuk to conclude his first recorded sermon in the Bible, prophesying a second fulfillment of the destruction of Jerusalem (Acts 13:41). And so, it was in 70 AD.

However, even as these words of Habakkuk were reminiscent of warnings uttered earlier by Isaiah in the days of the Assyrian peril (Isaiah 28:21–22; 29:14), so Paul now takes them up and applies them to the new situation in which God is offering deliverance through the greatest of all his mighty works which are eternal salvation by faith in the gospel, that is, the unexpected intervention of God relates to the conversion of the Gentiles.

“At the same time as the judgment would come on his people, the Jews, to whom His son the Lord Jesus came in person, for their unbelief, God is now offering deliverance through the greatest of all his mighty works which are eternal salvation by faith in the gospel.” As noted, scholar CH Dodd observes, “the unexpected intervention of God,” quoting Habakkuk 1:5, relates to the conversion of the Gentiles.” “Look, you scoffers, wonder and perish, for I am going to do something in your days that you would never believe, even if someone told you” Acts 13:41.

Great as was the disaster that overtook those who ignored the prophetic warnings, an even greater disaster will befall those who refuse the gospel. Unbelieving Israel harassed and contradicted Paul throughout the rest of his ministry, further validating Habakkuk’s prophecy in his day.

Luke interprets Habakkuk 1:5 as astonishment of God's work aimed at the conversion of the Gentiles including all the ethnē -- all the unreached peoples. In his sermon, quoted by Luke, Paul used the term ergos which normally was translated as ‘work’ in English to refer to the task of church planting. In fact, in classical philosophy ergos is translated by the word ‘‘task.’’



As prophesied by Paul in his first sermon, the work (ergos) God was going to do among the Gentiles – the ethnē – was amazing. As they served the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, “Separate Barnabas and Saul for me, for the work to which I have called them.”

By 48 AD the church was extending overseas with Paul, the missionary actively evangelizing, thus launching a church planting movement (CPM) for the next twelve years among the ethnē in Cyprus, Lystra, Philippi, Athens, Corinth, Ephesus, Macedonia, and Greece.

Along the way, Paul was sharing with the different people groups the “knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea.” As disciples were made and churches were formed, Luke could say, “the word grew and multiplied” (Acts 12:24). In this context, the apostle Paul quoted Habakkuk. 1:5,

applying the principle of God's dealings in Habakkuk's day to the new situation in the church in his day and thus setting the stage for a Finishing The Task movement with a CPM modality.

Quoting Habakkuk 1:5 as recorded in Acts 13:41, underscores the redemptive importance of Paul's "report" of God's "work" among the ethnē. To dispute, the report is to reject God's bid to save God's people. The Apostle Paul used Habakkuk 1:5 for the double fulfillment of the prophecy. Habakkuk prophesied before the arrival of the Chaldeans in Palestine. The first destruction of Jerusalem took place by the Chaldeans/Babylonians with the second destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans during the siege of 70 AD.



70 AD Jerusalem Destroyed

Paul and Barnabas accomplished the missionary "work" that the Holy Spirit had commissioned them to do in their day. Should we, servants of God, not accomplish the work that the Holy Spirit has commissioned us to do in our day? The repetition of the term "work," first in Acts 13:2. "As they served the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, 'Separate Barnabas and Saul for me, for the work to which I have called them.

As Paul and Barnabas were passing through Phoenicia and Samaria they were taking time to meet with believers who were Hellenized Jews, "describing in detail" with the fullest and clearest declaration what God had done resulting in the conversion of the Gentiles (Acts 15:3). The present tense pictures Paul and Barnabas continually describing in detail the Gentile reception of the Gospel of Jesus Christ, the true and living God!

Finishing the task includes the celebration of what God is doing among the unreached peoples of the world as we are doing in this event and calls us together to work as one body, regardless of church or denominational affiliation… regardless of nationality.

We are the Body of Christ. We are His servants called to do His will by finishing the task of making disciples among all the ethnē, a church for every people by 2030. Now is the time. Now is the opportunity. Do not miss it.

Conclusion: Fellow servants let us not fail to do our duty as God's servants for such a time as this. Never perhaps has the need been greater in our world as it is today. Let us join hearts and hands to fulfill our calling. Let us lay down our titles and minor doctrinal distinctives to ensure we keep the main thing the main thing. Jesus Christ is Lord. Jesus Christ is King. He commands us to make disciples of all the ethnē. Let us do it. From reflecting on the revelation let us write it down so as not to forget it. When Habakkuk sought God to see what He would say to him we read in 2:2 his response; "the LORD answered me: 'Write the vision; make it plain on tablets, so he may run who reads it.'" That is just what we need to do as God's servants.

II. Write down the vision. Make it plain. Record this vision to preserve it for posterity, so that all who read it would respond and run with that vision.

God is advancing His Kingdom purposes in our day leading to a world filled with the knowledge of His glory and inviting his servants to join Him on His mission of transformation. Habakkuk may well have reflected thoughtfully in his time and responded by writing down the precise wording (see Habakkuk 2:14) from Isaiah, his prophetic predecessor of almost 100 years, to describe the nature of a transformed world as a world filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea (Isaiah 11:9).

To finish the task and transform our world, as revealed by the prophet Habakkuk, we must fully engage the ultimate transformer, our living Lord Jesus. But how can we do that since the incarnation of our Lord Jesus was still yet to come?

We read in Isaiah 11:1: "There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse," -- "from the line of David," and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. And the Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the LORD. Righteousness shall be the belt of his waist, and faithfulness the belt of his loins." And the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the Lord as the waters cover the sea. Christ's Kingdom comes – it is a transformed world. He, that is Jesus, would signal to the nations a new reality (Isaiah 11:10) The Root of Jesse will stand as a banner for the peoples; the nations will rally to him…

In this shared vision of a transformed world Isaiah highlights three characteristics of a Kingdom Movement to transform the world – true then – true now. **A. Appointments, B. Attributes and C. Accomplishments to transform our world.**

A. **APPOINTMENT**S for transformation: it is all about Jesus as revealed in Isaiah 11:1 There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. Fresh life will emerge in a new catalytic agent of change, called a Rod and a Branch. The Messiah, the Root of Jesse, is Jesus Himself, who is also called the Root of David in Revelation 5:5. Jesus, the Messiah will bear the fruit on God's mission of world transformation. Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life in whom we live and move and have our being who prayed to the Father Your Kingdom come, your will be done on earth as it is in heaven. Kingdom Movement Paradigms in our day, as described in Isaiah 11, suggests that the time is near for finishing the task. Disciples are being made through ongoing Discovery Groups,

mentoring, coaching, and making other disciples. They are planting churches that plant other churches as a normal progression of the Spirit-filled life.

Mission Frontiers Magazine has reported that "Over the last 25 years…, the Holy Spirit has birthed hundreds of these Disciple Making Movements (DMMs) / Church Planting Movements (CPMs) among historically resistant peoples that have become Christ-followers in unprecedented numbers. At the end of 2018, there were more than 660 such movements according to their findings. To Finish the Task - Transform World beyond appointments we also need to have the…

B. **ATTRIBUTES for Transformation**, Isaiah 11:2 signals the seven-fold gifting of the Holy Spirit resting on Jesus. "And the Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the LORD. And his delight shall be in the fear of the LORD."

We see the Gospel of the Kingdom advancing in our day signaled by Disciple Making Movements (DMM's) characterized by their holistic nature and the transformation of cultures. God is raising people throughout the nations in our day who are becoming disciples of Christ with a lifestyle of obedience to God's Word. Thirdly, to Finish the Task -Transform World we need appointments, attributes, and the…)

C. ACCOMPLISHMENTS of Transformation which include the emergence of Kingdom Movements –

Kingdom Movements as illustrated in Isaiah 11:6 "The wolf shall dwell with the lamb, …the nursing child shall play over the hole of the cobra. That represents a transformed world in which they shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain (the Kingdom, Isaiah 2:2-3).

Models of Kingdom Movements in the world today typically envision things like systemic, sustainable change, health, healing, harmony, and wholeness but also these accomplishments of transformation in our day include the children of the world.

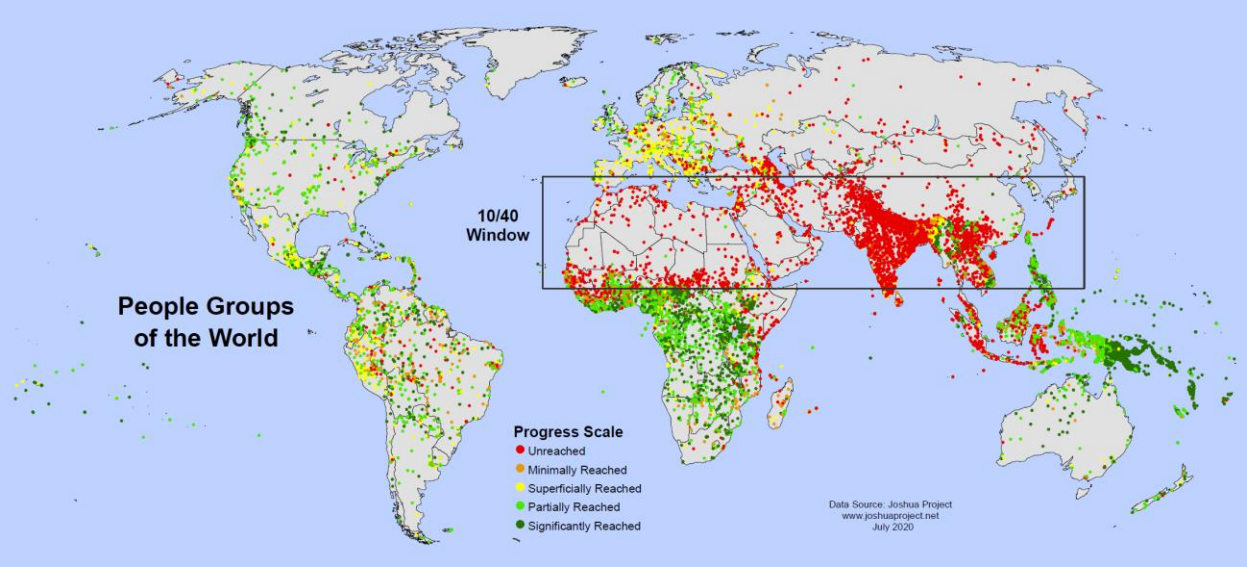
In these Kingdom Movements, the prophet highlights our need to reach, rescue, root in the Word of God, and release the children of the world – the "tender shoots" the 4/14ers in our world – as partners in our mission to transform the world. Where once children were victimized, they will enjoy the blessed freedom to roam and play. They will lead. <u>The child is referenced three times in the Messianic Kingdom in Isaiah 11.</u> This three-fold mention of young children immediately precedes the definitive description of a transformed world, God's way which includes the 4/14ers as his instruments to transform the world.

Christ's Kingdom comes by appointment with distinctive attributes of the master, our Lord Jesus Christ, that will lead to world transformation such that God's His will is done on earth as it is in heaven. In that day, the root of Jesse, the Lord Jesus, who shall stand as a signal for the peoples, of him shall the nations inquire, and his resting place shall be glorious. His Kingdom will come, and He will be done on earth as it is in heaven. It is about appointments, attributes, and accomplishments. It is about Jesus the way, the truth, and the life.

Servants of God to Finish the Task – by 2030 we need to reflect on the vision, write down the vision, and…

III. Run with the Vision of the Earth Filled with the Knowledge of the Glory of the Lord as the Waters Cover the Sea

Now is the time to run together. Commit to working together with young and old, male, and female Our goal is Disciple Making Movement – for every ethnē. We need to focus prayer and outreach on the unreached peoples. Joshua Project informs us that 84% of all the unreached people groups at this time are in the 10/40 Window

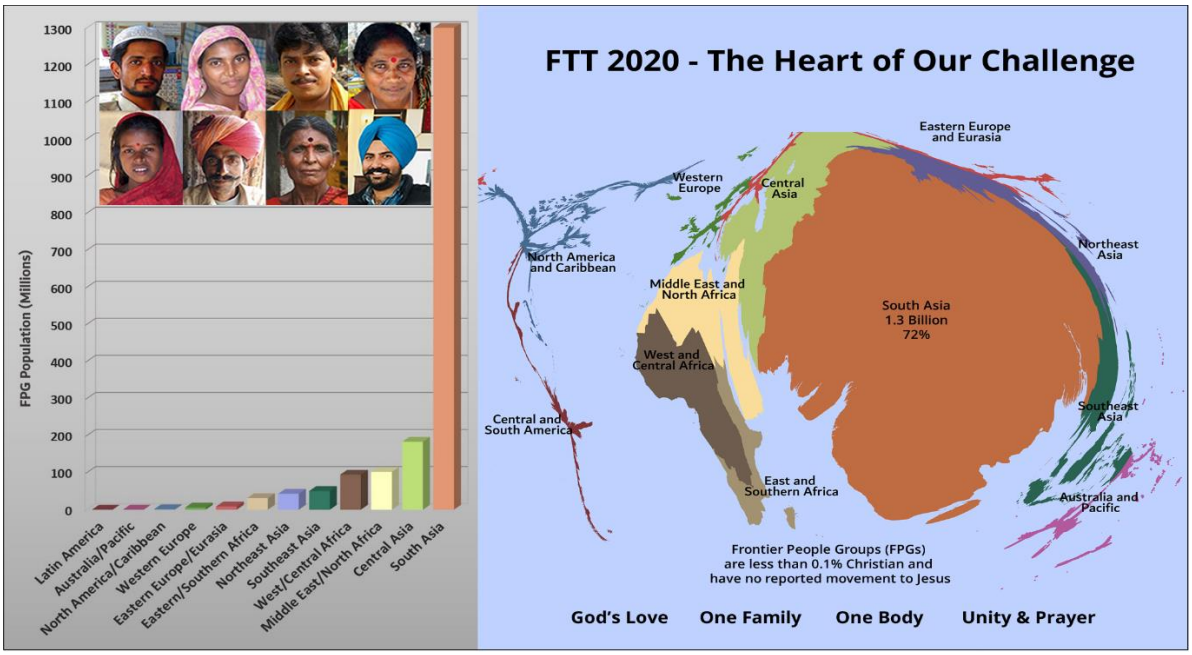


Preach the Gospel. We have the promise from on high that this gospel of the kingdom will be preached in the whole world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come, such that the earth is filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea until "the kingdoms of this world become the kingdoms of our Lord, and his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever."

We must work as Joshua Project encourages us to do to accomplish the following:

- Have workers in every people group – Finishing the Task (the organization) focus
- Have disciples/churches in every people group – IMB focus
- Have movements in every people group – 24:14 Initiative focus
- Impact every area of society – Transform World focus
- Have the full Scriptures available in every language – SIL/Wycliffe/Others focus
- Present the Gospel to every person – Cru/GMO/Jesus Film Project/Go2020 focus
- Adoption of every frontier people group in the heart of our mission challenge for prayer.

Mobilize prayer for the heart of our challenge – South Asia Frontier Peoples which 72% of the Frontier People Groups with less than .1% Christian



Jesus highlighted the work of seeking the lost in parables. He referred to his mission as finishing the work the father had sent him to do. Finish the task of reaching the unreached now is for you and me – to do**.** Let us join together as Christ-followers from every nation on earth. Now is the time. Now is the opportunity. It leads to rejoicing.

The last words of the Prophet Habakkuk were "…yet I will rejoice in the Lord, I will be joyful in the God of my salvation! The Sovereign Lord is my strength! He makes me as surefooted as a deer, able to tread upon the heights" (NLT Habakkuk. 3:18-19). Let us rejoice in God our Savior for He shall reign forever and ever.